

she'd graduated from broker's school and had become a full-fledged stockbroker herself.

Most of her colleagues were stuck out in the middle of a big open room, but they'd given Ms. Garrett a private office along the wall. That impressed me. Also, she didn't used to dress this well. As a secretary, she looked like she worked for the Clamshell Alliance, but now she would have fit in at the Republican National Committee.

I'm mentioning these factors because I don't know which may have contributed to the surprising decision that followed. As the two of us sat in Ms. Garrett's private office, I could see the stocks displayed on her Quotron, rising in value by the second. These were her own picks, she said. One called Genentech went up two points as I shifted my weight in the chair. Ms. Garrett mentioned she'd been buying Genentech for several clients. A happy phone call from one of the clients interrupted our conversation.

There was a second, longer phone call from Philadelphia. I heard only Ms. Garrett's side of it, which I remember as: "over-the-counter," "chemical field," "maybe in line for government contracts," "likely to double by Christmas," and "if this works out, I'll buy you an ice cream."

"What works out?" I demanded to know, after she'd hung up. Ms. Garrett explained it was just some little stock she was buying for herself and close friends, wouldn't be suitable for regular clients, too speculative. She said she didn't really want to sell it to me. After all I'd been through, that alone was enough to insure my interest.

"How much is it?" I asked.

"About \$1.50 per share last time I looked."

"What's this about it doubling by Christmas?" (It was December 12 at the time, and I'd been studying, researching, and investigating for nearly two months.)

"I don't know. He thinks it might."

"Who thinks so?"

"The person I was talking to."

She'd only tell me that her source was a knowledgeable investor, the one who'd get the ice cream if this recommendation worked